

# The Astronaut Who Might Actually Get Us to Mars

The improbable journey of Franklin Chang Díaz, who immigrated to the U.S. at eighteen, became an astronaut, tied the record for most spaceflights, and now might hold the key to deep space travel.



By Katy Vine

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Franklin Chang Díaz at the Ad Astra offices on Thursday, December 21, 2017.

**Photographs by Jeff Wilson**

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We like to tell stories—often in blockbuster films and children’s books—that dramatize a direct path from the initial spark of an idea to its realization. Decades of hard work and failed attempts are condensed into a brief montage that concludes with triumph. Thomas Edison thought electricity could illuminate the world, so he developed the lightbulb. John Atanasoff was frustrated by the limitations of late-twenties calculators, so he devised his own and soon followed it up with the first electronic digital computer. President Kennedy said we’d go to the moon, so we poured money and manpower into a rocket, and Neil Armstrong took one giant leap for mankind.

Except, we know, the actual narrative is more complicated. Take that last example. When Kennedy gave his speech in May 1961, the genius rocket engineer Wernher von Braun and his team, which eventually found a home